



“WHAT MANMOHAN SINGH DID FOR THE ECONOMY in 1991, we will do the same for the education sector in 2009.”

Q. The other burning issue is the examination system with a multiplicity of Central and state higher secondary boards imposing their own norms? What needs to be done?

A. We must have an education system that is trauma-free. Now, when a child is in Class X or XII, not only is he in trauma but also his parents. It means that you should not make the child's future dependent on one exam. Can we, as people, evolve a system that will ultimately make education trauma-free? Why should we have a two-board system? May we think in terms of abolishing the Class X board? Let the movement of

the child depend on his performance. And you can have an internal examination every three or four months. The problem with enforcing an alternative system is that there is not enough integrity within the school system to ensure that it will be free of favouritism. This is a very serious problem.

Q. Part of the reason for a Class X Board was to give options to students for vocational training. But that hasn't been successful.

A. That's the other thing I have decided to focus on. Today we mainly have three streams—science, commerce and humanities, which is meaningless. Somebody wants to be a

hands-on engineer, a mechanic, why should he not get that training. Somebody wants to be an IT professional, we should have training at that level. We need to bring into the system vocational courses at the higher secondary level. China offers 4,000 vocational courses. And then, these vocational courses can be a stepping stone to polytechnics and the skill development institutions that have already been decided to be set up by the Government.

Q. Coming to school education, the governments now control everything, including determining the teachers' salary and seat reservations. How can this sector be freed up?

A. We need to have a mechanism for accreditation of schools. Any school anywhere in the country

a multiplicity of agencies. He says: “In a hurry to do things they created mini boxes all over and built walls. Take the Medical Council of India—it should really be ensuring that doctors who are let loose on the society take care of the sick and not kill them. How is it qualified to put hurdles and decide what should be taught in medical colleges?” His committee has now recommended that rather than the maze of agencies, the government set up an autonomous National Commission for Higher Education and Research as a constitutional body that would function like a regulatory authority without undermining academic freedom and institutional autonomy. The NKC had advocated something similar. Rather than the inspection approval method, the Commission is expected to evolve a system of verification and authentication that would be transparent and in the public domain. The UGC and other regulatory agencies would be subsumed into the new Commission and divested of its academic function. Sibal has indicated that the Government will work towards implementing these recommendations.

Privatisation is Key

Surreptitious privatisation has already occurred in the education sector but the current crisis now calls for a full opening out. Yash Pal believes that privatisation is needed but with regulations. He says, “It should not be run like a private business where the promoter first becomes a chancellor and then makes his 25-year-old son the vice-chancellor.”